

Moscow Zoo



The **Moscow Zoo** or **Moskovsky Zoopark** is one of the oldest zoos in Europe, dating back to 1864. Located in the city centre, the zoo is a favourite place for families with children and a popular tourist attraction. At weekends and during holidays, there are long queues in front of the ticket offices by the central entrance. The zoo is home to about 1,132 species, second only to the Berlin Zoological Garden in the European rankings. Primates, elephants, giraffes, tigers, lions, brown bears and polar bears, penguins, rare birds, and seals are kept on a 22-ha plot of land.

History

It was founded in 1864 by professor-biologists, K.F. Rulje, S.A. Usov and A.P. Bogdanov, from Moscow State University. In 1919, the zoo was nationalized. In 1922, the ownership was transferred to the Government of Moscow and has remained under Moscow's control ever since. The zoo had an area of 10 hectares (25 acres) when it first opened, with 286 animals. In 1926, the zoo was expanded to adjacent lands, increasing the area to 18 hectares (44 acres). The zoo's original buildings were wooden, built in the Old Russian style with intricate wooden trims.

During World War II, the Moscow Zoo remained open though much of the park was destroyed.

In 1990, the zoo was renovated. Notable additions include a new main entrance in the shape of a large rock castle, and a footbridge that connected the old (1864) and new (1926) properties of the zoo. Prior to construction of the footbridge, the zoo operated as two 'separate zoos' because Bolshaya Gruzinskaya Street divided the properties.

In addition, the zoo was expanded once more. In 1997 new exhibitions were opened including a sea aquarium, an aviary, a night creatures' exhibition, a sea lion exhibition and a section aimed at children. Waterfalls and streams were added throughout to give the zoo a more natural feeling.

The latest renovation of the zoo took place in 2014. That year the zoo celebrated its 150th anniversary. As a result, the pony riding circle, the internal enclosures of the Monkey House, rooms for nutria, otters, wolverines, aviaries for animals of South America and Australia, the "Bird Row" were completely updated. The most noticeable change was the renewal of ponds on the Old territory.

Areas and attractions

The Moscow Zoo consists of two areas - the 'Old' and 'New'. They are connected with a footbridge across Bolshaya Gruzinskaya Street. In the New Territory of the zoo, you will see a natural coral reef and giant butterflies, meet monkeys, crocodiles, giraffes, polar bears, tigers, and other animals. A pedestrian bridge will take you into the Old Territory where you will find elephants, leopards, cheetahs and other felines, as well as penguins, wolves, and seals.

The Moscow Zoo is a massive area and includes anything you can possibly imagine. The place is divided into 36 sections: Big Pond, Flamingo, Tropical Cats, the Cat String, Cheetahs, Spectacled Bears, The Giraffe House, White-tailed Gnus and Tapirs, Dogs and Relatives, Ungulates, Pinnipeds, Delphinarium, House of Birds, Cranes, Elephant House, Peccaries and Bush Pigs, Musk Oxen and Mountain Goats, Pony Ring, Rock of Birds of Prey, Animals of Russia, Nocturnal World, South America, Australia Fauna, Crossover Bridge, Pond of the New Territory, Coatis and Otters, Polar world, Mountain Ungulates, Pelicans and Cormorants, Fauna of Indonesia, Insecttopia, Deer, Przewalski Horses, Camels, the Animal Island, Exotarium, African Ungulates, Horses, Primates, the Reptile House and Children Zoo.

Moscow Zoo Museum

The Moscow Zoo Museum was founded in 2008 in a two-storey building of the 19th century, built in the late XIX - early XX centuries, located on the territory of the zoo. Since 2015, the museum has been open to the public. In the central and side halls there is an exposition devoted to the history of the Moscow Zoo and a natural science permanent exposition. The collection of the museum includes more than 10,000 zoo coat of arms from all over the world, hundreds of paintings, sculptures and drawings by the masters of Russian animalistics, such as Vasily Vatagin, Alexei Komarov, Vadim Trofimov, Andrei Marts and Alexei Tsvetkov.

Research & Educational Centre

The Moscow Zoo has its own educational institute and research centre. In addition to full-training for zoo staff and teachers, there is a continuing education programme for zoo and aquarium staff, veterinarians, teachers and volunteers, as well as courses in zoo psychology. Since the Moscow Zoo has been chairman of all zoos in Russia since the Soviet period, it is a national training centre. It was founded in 2017 by the current director Svetlana Akulova and Björn Stenvers.

The Moscow Zoo has a number of educational programmes for children of different ages: Young biologist Club, Novice travellers, Programmes for schools, Pony Club, Art Zebra, Children's studio "Colour", Museum Lessons, Open lecture hall and others. The programmes are designed both to expand knowledge about animals as well as nature and to improve knowledge of the native language, develop interest in foreign languages, expand knowledge in geography, acquire skills in handling animals, develop creative skills and creative thinking, as well as other useful skills and knowledge that help the children in comprehensive development.

Notable animals

Bear Maryam was brought up at the Moscow Zoo and starred in the film "A Tale of a Real Man". Maryam was distinguished by her friendly character and good-natured disposition, which is rare among bears. Vera Chaplina made Maryam the heroine of her story "Maryam and Jack", included in the collection "Pets of the zoo".

Giraffe Samson Gamletovich Leningradov was born on August 5, 1993 in the Leningrad Zoo. His parents were a native of Denmark giraffe Hamlet and giraffe Meadows. At the age of two, he moved to Moscow, settled in a separate aviary ("Giraffe House") of the Moscow Zoo, the oldest on the Old territory, built back in 1892. Samson became the only inhabitant of the zoo to receive a full name. He quickly gained popularity among visitors, despite the fact that the zoo has other giraffes living in a common enclosure with zebras. Now Samson is one of the symbols of the zoo.

Location and travel options for visitors

The Moscow Zoo is located in the Presnensky district, about 4 miles (6 kilometers) west of downtown Moscow between the Garden Ring and Third Ring Road. The closest metro stations are Barrikadnaya (line 7) and Krasnopresnenskaya (line 5), each just a 2-minute walk away. It is easy to get to the Moscow Zoo by metro. Few people know that the Moscow Zoo has two entrances: the central one, from Bolshaya Gruzinskaya Street and another one, from the Garden Ring. You can also buy tickets at this entrance where the queues are much smaller; moreover, it is easier to start your walk around the zoo from here.